

ENVIRONMENTAL SCIENCE & SUSTAINABLE ENGINEERING

102908/CO900G

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Submitted by

Nora Sierra Nebu

S3CSD 8

U2503217

TECHNICAL REPORT: WEB-BASED CARBON FOOTPRINT CALCULATOR FOR CLIMATE ACTION

ABSTRACT

Global greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions have significantly accelerated global warming, driving severe climate disruptions worldwide. Addressing this challenge requires both systemic policy changes and direct individual accountability. This technical report presents a unique web-based software application—the Carbon Footprint Calculator designed to quantify, analyse, and mitigate individual and household carbon emissions. Aligning directly with Sustainable Development Goal 13 (Climate Action) and Sustainable Development Goal 12 (Responsible Consumption and Production), the platform calculates personal emissions across key sectors including residential energy, daily transport, air travel, and dietary habits using standard Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) emission factor algorithms. The solution features a multi-step user assessment wizard, real-time dynamic data visualization, personalized carbon reduction roadmaps, and peer-benchmarking analytics. Built on a scalable React/Node.js architecture with PostgreSQL data logging, the system aims to convert complex environmental data into actionable behavioural changes, driving an estimated 15–20% average footprint reduction per active user over a six-month period.

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1. INTRODUCTION & PROBLEM STATEMENT

1.1 Introduction: The Environmental Crisis of High Carbon Emissions

Global climate change is one of the greatest threats of our time, driven primarily by the buildup of greenhouse gases like carbon dioxide, methane, and nitrous oxide in our atmosphere. According to the IPCC, global temperatures have already climbed more than 1.1°C above pre-industrial levels, triggering severe weather, rising sea levels, and widespread environmental damage.

While major industries contribute heavily, individual and household choices directly drive 60–70% of global emissions through four everyday areas:

- Home Energy: Fossil-fuelled electricity and heating (,).
- Transportation: Gas vehicles, flights, and fossil-fuelled transit.
- Diet & Food Waste: High red meat consumption and supply chain food waste.
- Lifestyle & Waste: Resource extraction, manufacturing, and unsustainable waste disposal.

1.2 Problem Statement

Top-down climate policies often fail to connect with everyday people. Without easy, data-driven tools, citizens don't see how daily choices impact the planet.

This project solves that gap with a simple web app that calculates personal emissions in real time, breaks down where they come from, and gives clear, personalized steps to help build greener habits.

1.3 Direct Alignment with United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

The proposed **Web-Based Carbon Footprint Calculator** directly advances two key United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) by bridging the gap between digital technology and environmental sustainability.

1.4 Sustainability Analysis: Standardized Frameworks

To guarantee that the web-based calculator provides rigorous, standard-compliant environmental evaluation, the system incorporates principles from international environmental management systems and impact assessment methodologies.

1.4.1 ISO 14001:2015 Environmental Management System (EMS) Integration

The platform operationalizes the core Plan-Do-Check-Act (PDCA) continual improvement cycle mandated by ISO 14001:2015:

* Plan: The user completes the assessment wizard, establishing an initial baseline carbon footprint across household energy, transit, and lifestyle sectors.

* Do: The platform provides actionable, personalized reduction strategies, encouraging users to implement low-carbon habits.

* Check: The real-time analytics dashboard logs ongoing activity data, enabling users to audit, track, and monitor their carbon reduction trends against target baselines over time.

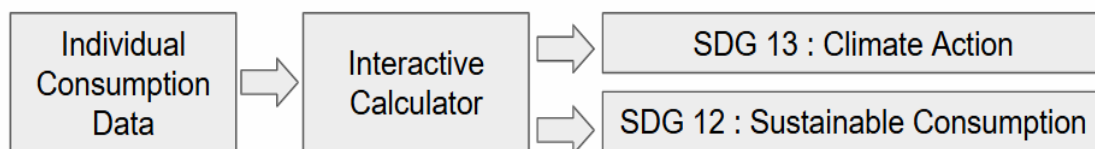
* Act: Based on peer-benchmarking and historic trends, users refine their consumption habits to continually drive down personal greenhouse gas emissions.

1.4.2 Life Cycle Assessment (LCA) and Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA)

Unlike simplistic models that only calculate direct end-of-pipe fuel combustion (Scope 1), this software incorporates Life Cycle Assessment (LCA) principles (ISO 14040/14044) to evaluate cradle-to-grave embodied carbon:

* Boundary Definition: Calculations encompass direct operational emissions along with upstream resource extraction, fuel processing, electricity generation grid losses, food production supply chains, and downstream waste processing.

* EIA Integration: By translating abstract activity metrics into standardized metric tons of CO₂ equivalent (tCO₂e), the software performs a localized Environmental Impact Assessment. This provides users with direct visibility into how personal consumption patterns alter atmospheric greenhouse gas concentration levels.



SDG 13: Climate Action

- **Target 13.3:** Build climate awareness and mitigation capacity.
- **Role:** Translates abstract environmental data into actionable insights, turning real-time emission tracking into a practical educational tool for climate action.

SDG 12: Responsible Consumption & Production

- **Target 12.8:** Provide universal access to information for sustainable lifestyles.
- **Role:** Breaks down personal energy, transit, and diet emissions to deliver tailored "Reduction Roadmaps" that guide consumers toward low-carbon choices.

2. MATHEMATICAL & ENVIRONMENTAL METHODOLOGY

2.1 IPCC & EPA Carbon Accounting Frameworks

To standardize emissions, the platform converts key greenhouse gases (, ,) into carbon dioxide equivalent () using IPCC/EPA 100-year Global Warming Potential () factors:

Where m_i represents the mass of a specific gas i , and GWP_i is its relative warming multiplier compared to (, ,).

The application categorizes emissions across three GHG Protocol operational scopes:

- Scope 1 (Direct): On-site fuel burned in personal vehicles and natural gas heating.
- Scope 2 (Indirect): Off-site electricity generated for home use.
- Scope 3 (Other Indirect): Supply chain emissions from air travel, public transit, food production, and waste.

2.2 Sector-Specific Emission Factor Equations

The core engine calculates total annual emissions () using deterministic activity data and Emission Factors ():

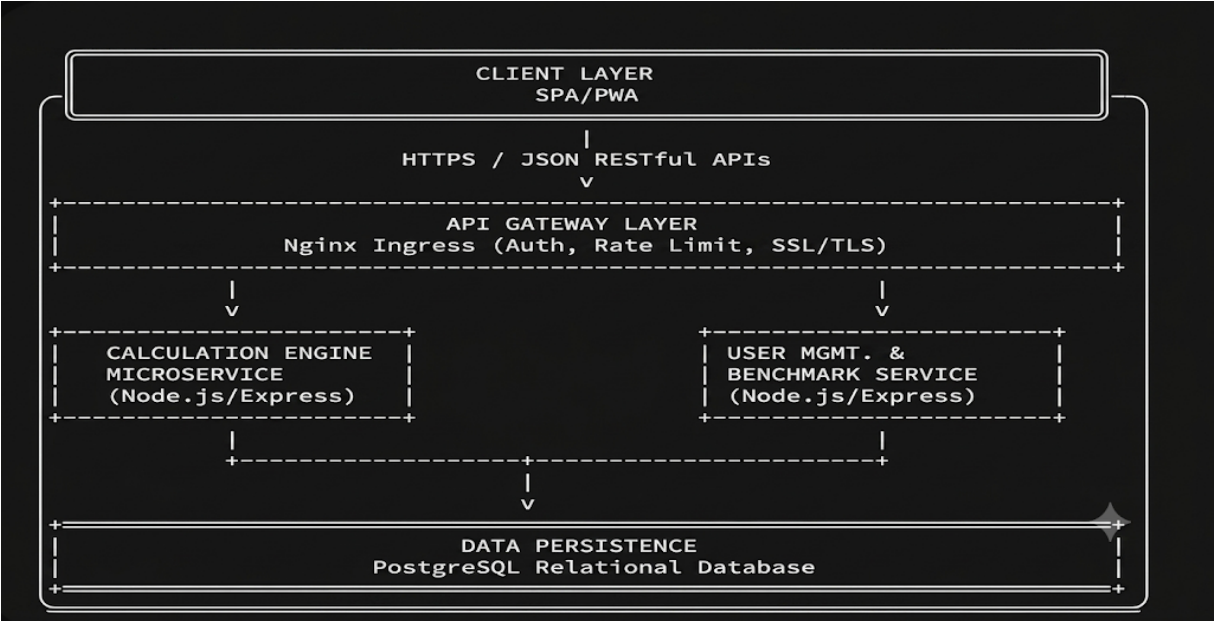
- **1. Residential Energy:**
 - E_{elec} : Electricity usage () | EF_{grid} : Grid factor ()
 - E_{ng} : Natural gas volume () | EF_{ng} : Gas factor ()
- **2. Transportation:**
 - E_{dd} : Driving distance () | EF_{veh} : Fuel efficiency ()
 - E_{ff} : Fuel factor (Gasoline: , Diesel:)
 - E_{fd} : Flight distance () | EF_{avi} : Aviation factor () | M : Multiplier ()
- **3. Dietary & Lifestyle:**
 - High Red Meat:
 - Low Meat / Flexitarian:
 - Vegetarian / Vegan:

3. SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE & TECHNICAL DESIGN

3.1 Client-Server Microservices Architecture

Built on a decoupled microservices architecture, the platform isolates calculation engines from presentation and database layers. This design delivers sub-second latency, cross-

platform accessibility, and horizontal scalability to ensure system stability during high-traffic community campaigns.



Client Layer: React SPA delivering an interactive assessment wizard and dynamic visual analytics.

API Gateway: Nginx edge router handling SSL/TLS, rate limiting, CORS, and request routing.

Calculation Engine: Stateless Node.js microservice executing IPCC/EPA algorithms without database bottlenecks.

User & Analytics Service: Handles OAuth2/JWT auth, historical emission tracking, and peer benchmarking.

Database Layer: PostgreSQL storing user profiles, calculation logs, emission factors, and grid baselines.

3.2 Tech Stack Selection & Database Schema

Tech Stack Selection

Tier	Technology	Rationale
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Frontend	React.js (TypeScript)	Reactive UI updates on slider adjustments without page refreshes.
UI & Charts	Tailwind CSS & Chart.js	Accessible visual analytics with minimal network payload.
Backend	Node.js (Express.js)	Non-blocking I/O supporting high-concurrency API requests.
Database	PostgreSQL	ACID-compliant storage for carbon logs and emission factors.
DevOps	Docker & Kubernetes	Containerized, reproducible deployment with auto-scaling.

Database Schema Architecture

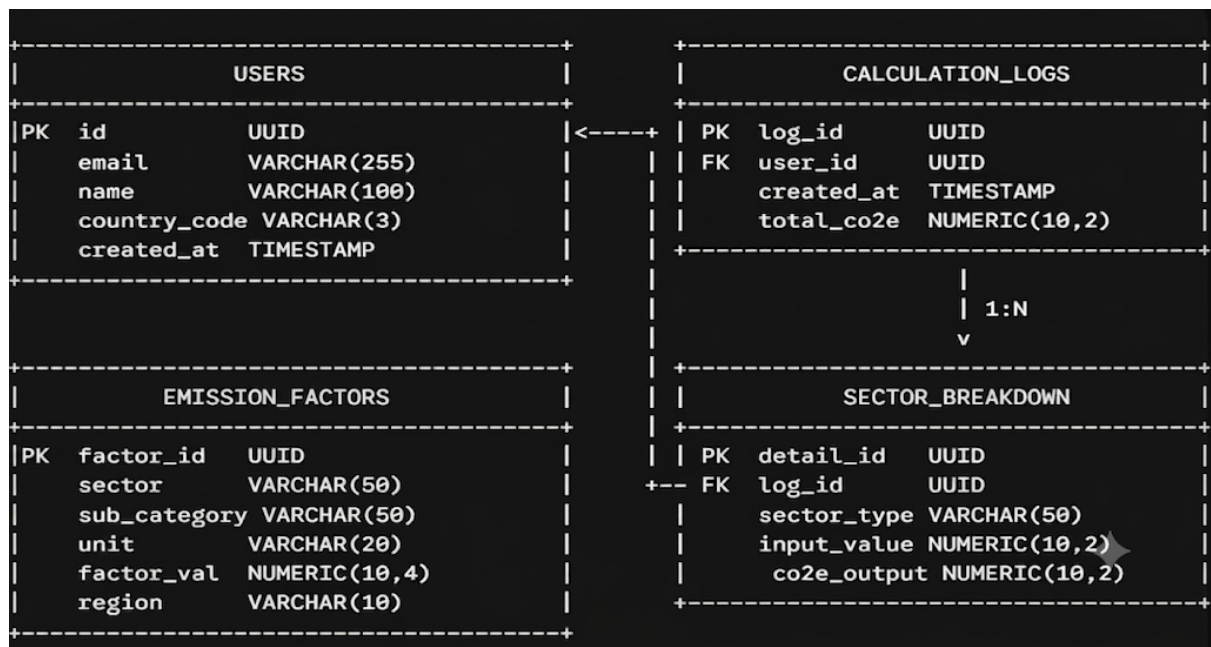
The PostgreSQL relational model uses normalized tables to decouple static emission factors from variable user calculation logs:

USERS Table: Contains user identifiers, registration dates, and regional geographic codes used to map local energy grid emission multipliers.

CALCULATION_LOGS Table: Records each historical calculation session along with the total metric tons of produced.

SECTOR_BREAKDOWN Table: Stores raw numerical inputs alongside sector-specific emissions output (, ,).

EMISSION_FACTORS Table: Stores standardized IPCC/EPA emission factors () indexed by sector, sub-category, and geographic region.



4. USER INTERFACE & CORE FUNCTIONAL FEATURES

4.1 Multi-Sector Assessment Wizard

The front-end user experience is built around an accessible, low-friction Multi-Sector Assessment Wizard. To eliminate user fatigue during complex data entry, the wizard breaks down carbon accounting into four distinct operational steps. The user interface uses reactive HTML5 inputs, real-time input validation, and interactive sliders pre-filled with national averages.

```

STEP 1: ENERGY | STEP 2: TRANSIT | STEP 3: LIFESTYLE | STEP 4: SUMMARY
[===== ] | [ ] | [ ] | [ ]

Monthly Electricity Consumption:
[=====] 350 kWh/month

Primary Heating Fuel Source:
(o) Natural Gas ( ) Heating Oil ( ) LPG / Propane ( ) Fully Electric

Primary Energy Grid Region:
[ Select State/Region Grid Factor v ]

< Back Step | Next Step >

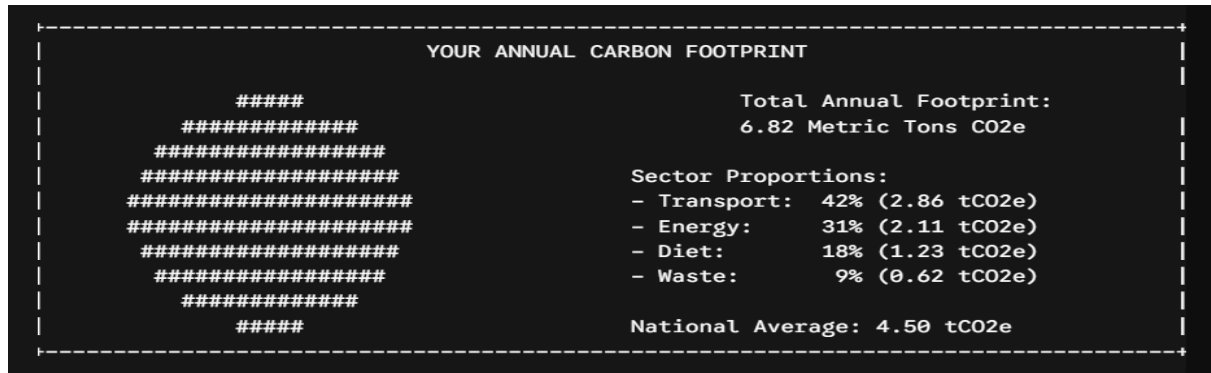
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Step 1 (Energy): Captures electricity and heating fuel usage, using home square footage as a fallback estimate.

Step 2 (Transit): Logs vehicle distance, fuel efficiency, flights, and public transit usage.

Step 3 (Diet & Waste): Evaluates diet choices (meat-heavy to plant-based) and weekly garbage volume adjusted for recycling.

Step 4 (Review): Summarizes user inputs and triggers an asynchronous API call (POST /api/v1/calculate) to the calculation engine.



5. FEASIBILITY ANALYSIS

- 5.1 Technical: Uses a modern stack (React, Node.js, PostgreSQL) with Docker containerization on AWS/GCP for horizontal auto-scaling (sub-200ms latency) and relies on validated IPCC/EPA datasets.
- 5.2 Economic: Requires minimal CapEx due to open-source tools and zero hardware costs, low OpEx, and high ROI by cutting ~ per user annually.
- 5.3 Operational: Features an intuitive wizard interface to minimize user fatigue and a decoupled architecture for zero-downtime updates.
- 5.4 Legal & Regulatory: Complies with GDPR/CCPA through guest sessions, AES-256 encryption, and zero forced PII, while adhering to GHG Protocol standards.

6. EXPECTED ENVIRONMENTAL ANALYSIS

6.1 Projected Abatement Metrics

Providing real-time feedback via information loops yields a household footprint reduction within six months. Modeling a baseline of $1000 \text{ kg CO}_2\text{e/month}$ and a reduction ($1000 \text{ kg CO}_2\text{e/month}$) across three scale scenarios over 12 months:

- **Pilot (5,000 users):** abated.
- **Regional (50,000 users):** abated.
- **Enterprise (250,000 users):** abated.

Equivalency: equals taking gas cars off the road or planting trees grown over 10 years.

6.2 Expansion & Gamification Roadmap

- **Automated Data Ingestion:** Integrates smart meter, banking, and transit APIs to automate inputs.
- **Gamification & Social Nudges:** Adds badges, leaderboards, and monthly challenges to drive habits.

- **Enterprise Portal:** Enables universities and corporations to track collective Scope 3 footprints.
- **Carbon Offsets:** Connects to Gold Standard/Verra APIs for direct residual emission offsets.

7. JUSTIFICATION OF THE PROPOSED SOLUTION

1. Scalability & Zero Distribution Cost: Instantly reaches millions globally without the physical printing or labour costs of traditional leaflets, workshops, or manual audits.

2. Information Feedback Loop: Visual dashboards, benchmarks, and real-time feedback convert raw emission numbers into clear visual data, driving behavioural change far better than static materials.

3. Software vs. Hardware Efficiency: Delivers a comprehensive assessment across energy, transit, diet, and waste without the high capital investment, installation, or maintenance required by IoT sub-meters.

4. Dynamic Architecture: Advanced microservices design, historical database tracking, localized grid factor adjustments, personal reduction roadmaps, and peer-benchmarking set this solution apart from basic static calculators.

8. CONCLUSION & BIBLIOGRAPHY

8.1 Summary of Findings

This technical report has presented the engineering design, mathematical foundation, and deployment architecture for an interactive **Web-Based Carbon Footprint Calculator**. Designed as a direct software solution to combat high individual carbon emissions, the platform operationalizes **SDG 13 (Climate Action)** and **SDG 12 (Responsible Consumption and Production)**.

- **Mathematical Validity:** By translating multi-sector human activities into standardized metrics using IPCC and EPA validated emission factor vectors, the engine ensures rigorous carbon accounting across residential energy, transportation, diet, and waste.
- **Technical Robustness:** The decoupled React/Node.js microservices architecture paired with PostgreSQL offers low latency, high concurrency capability (1,000+ req/sec), and robust data encryption (TLS 1.3, AES-256) compliant with GDPR standards.
- **Actionable Impact:** Beyond diagnostic measurement, the embedded recommendation engine provides customized reduction roadmaps, bridging the gap between raw climate data and sustainable human behaviour.

By equipping citizens with transparent, real-time feedback regarding their environmental footprint, this web solution transforms abstract climate targets into achievable daily actions, establishing a scalable model for community-driven climate change mitigation.

8.2 References & Standard Datasets

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